wars'. [41] The 'loss of India', Churchill argued, would be 'final and fatal' for Britain and would 'reduce us to the scale of a minor power'.[42] Thus, for Churchill, India was the 'most truly bright and precious jewel in the crown of the King' whose loss 'would mark and consummate the downfall of the British Empire'.[43]

When it came to the question of India's independence, Churchill insisted that after two centuries the British had rights and interests that they needed to defend.[44] 'India,' he claimed in a conversation with a leading Indian businessman, 'is a burden to us. We have to maintain an army and for the sake of India we have to maintain Singapore and Near East strength.'[45] British rule over India, in Churchill's view, was a favour to India and Britain was having to incur the additional responsibility of colonizing other countries and regions to facilitate India's defence. To Churchill, calls for India's independence interfered not only with Britain's global role but also with the contribution Britain was making towards India itself.

Most British Indian civil and military officials held views similar to Churchill's on India. In a conversation with Churchill during World War II, General Claude Auchinleck, stated: 'India is vital to our existence. We could still hold India without the Middle East, but we cannot hold the Middle East without India.' [46] Auchinleck was commander of British forces in the western desert at the time and later became commander-in-chief of the Indian Army and supreme commander of all British Forces in India and Pakistan.

This view that India and its army were critical to British global policy led to frequent disagreements between the government in London and the administration in Delhi. The former sought an army, which could be deployed globally while the latter preferred to use the force to curb domestic unrest and maintain its borders. Both the 1938 and 1939 Committees of Imperial Defence argued that India was 'the most suitable